

CHARACTER SKETCH: THE WHO

This is your journalist, Ishita Sudhir, with the character sketch of WHO.

The WHO committee seems to have a rather peculiar way of keeping themselves busy. Almost every discussion seemed to find its way towards a stronger regulation, international cooperation, better enforcement, and even improved access, but only to deliberate the same concerns from yet another direction. The arguments raised were not necessarily weak, but there was an odd familiarity in each one of them. One could almost predict as to where the next point was heading towards even before the delegate had concluded. WHO seemed less interested in changing the conversation than in making sure that the conversation never stopped. However, there was a certain patience to this. Unlike the other committees, where every disagreement seemed to turn into an opportunity for another confrontation, WHO seemed to prefer keeping things purely diplomatic. Even when the member states seemed to approach the issue from different interests, the discussion repeatedly found its way back to cooperation. It was as if WHO had made peace with the possibility that the agreement may take time and perhaps repetitions of the same age-old solutions.

Its approach to the Ministerial Declaration was none quite different. Once the delegates were divided into blocks and asked to identify the problems they faced, WHO seemed quite comfortable in its new arrangement. It was perhaps the committee at its most natural form. It



¹is taking a complicated problem, giving everyone a little space to discuss it and then hoping that somewhere in the heart of all these discussions a solution might emerge. There is something almost endearing about the committee's faith in deliberation. It does not seem particularly interested in dramatic declarations or easy answers. If anything, it appears slightly suspicious of them. Every solution seems to

require another discussion, every discussion another perspective, and every perspective another opportunity for cooperation. The process may seem to be slow, yet WHO seems to trust the process anyway.

¹ A glimpse into the committee. A picture from an IP photojournalist

Maybe that is also where its character becomes most apparent. It is not a committee that demands attention. It quietly accumulates it through repetition. Neither is it particularly confrontational nor is it entirely passive. It listens, revisits, negotiates, and moves forward. Even if the distance covered sometimes feels considerably smaller than the amount of the discussion involved. It showed the patience to listen. It was diplomatic enough to compromise when needed. Above all, it was optimistic enough to believe that the next round of discussion might perhaps be the one where everyone agrees.